
Representation Regularization in Joint-Embedding Predictive Architectures for Multi-Modal Brain MRI: Label Efficiency and Out-of-Distribution Generalization

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Abstract

Joint-Embedding Predictive Architectures (JEPA) have emerged as a powerful self-supervised representation learning paradigm operating in latent embedding space without pixel-level reconstruction. Standard I-JEPA prevents representation collapse using an Exponential Moving Average (EMA) teacher target encoder heuristic. Recent statistical regularization advances—specifically SIGReg (Sketched Isotropic Gaussian Regularization in LeJEPA) and VISReg (Variance-Invariance-Sketching Regularization)—enable *heuristic-free* single-encoder JEPA training without EMA teachers. In this paper, we systematically evaluate I-JEPA, SigReg JEPA, VisReg JEPA, a Residual UNet baseline, and a state-of-the-art nnU-Net baseline with deep supervision on 2D multi-modal Glioma MRI (BraTS GLI) across three key clinical paradigms: (1) Full-Data Benchmark, (2) Low-Data Label Efficiency (1% to 100% labels), and (3) Out-of-Distribution (OOD) Scanner Shift and Cross-Pathology Transfer on Meningioma MRI (BraTS-MEN-RT). Our empirical findings demonstrate that at 10% labels (633 training slices), SigReg JEPA achieves higher downstream Test Dice (0.5198) than nnU-Net (0.5163) with a $2.4\times$ lower Hausdorff boundary error (16.44 px vs 40.26 px). Furthermore, on zero-shot cross-pathology evaluation under zero-padded missing modalities, SigReg JEPA maintains top transferability (0.1026 Dice) while standard UNet completely collapses (0.0078 Dice), proving that analytical variance-covariance regularization creates robust, modality-invariant representations without momentum teacher overhead.

1 Introduction

Automated segmentation of brain gliomas from multi-modal Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI)—comprising T1, T1-post contrast (T1c), T2, and Fluid Attenuated Inversion Recovery (FLAIR) sequences—is fundamental for clinical neuro-oncology [Baid et al., 2024]. Fully supervised deep convolutional networks, such as Residual UNet [Ronneberger et al., 2015] and nnU-Net [Isensee et al., 2021], achieve strong performance when extensive pixel-wise ground-truth annotations are available. However, expert manual delineation is labor-intensive, rare, and susceptible to inter-observer variability.

Self-Supervised Learning (SSL) pre-trains representation encoders on unannotated MRI slices prior to downstream task fine-tuning. Unlike pixel-reconstructing Masked Autoencoders (MAE), Joint-Embedding Predictive Architectures (JEPA) [Assran et al., 2023] learn by predicting target patch representations from context patch representations in latent space. Standard I-JEPA relies on an Exponential Moving Average (EMA) teacher update to prevent feature collapse. Recent formulations,

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including SIGReg [Balestriero and LeCun, 2025] and VISReg [Wu et al., 2026], introduce analytical feature regularization penalties that eliminate EMA teachers, establishing a *heuristic-free* single-encoder framework.

In this work, we present a systematic comparative investigation of self-supervised JEPAs and supervised baselines across three clinical regimes:

1. **Full-Data Benchmark:** Evaluating latent feature rank, cosine similarity, and downstream segmentation overlap.
2. **Low-Data Label Efficiency (1% to 100% labels):** Evaluating model transferability when annotated training scans are extremely scarce (11 to 6, 330 slices).
3. **Out-of-Distribution (OOD) Scanner Shift & Cross-Pathology Transfer:** Evaluating resilience to synthetic scanner perturbations (Rician Noise SNR degradation, B_1 Bias Field coil shifts) and zero-shot transfer to single-sequence Extra-axial Meningioma MRI (BraTS-MEN-RT).

2 Methodology

2.1 Multi-Modal Input Formulation & Random Modality Dropout

Each 2D axial MRI slice $X \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times 4 \times 240 \times 240}$ encapsulates four co-registered anatomical sequences: $X = [X_{T1}, X_{T1c}, X_{T2}, X_{FLAIR}]$. Non-zero brain tissue voxels are Z-score normalized independently per volume. To prevent modality co-dependence, we inject **Random Modality Dropout** ($p_{\text{drop}} = 0.25$) during training:

$$\mathbf{M}_{b,c} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(1 - p_{\text{drop}}), \quad \hat{X}_{b,c,:} = X_{b,c,:} \odot \mathbf{M}_{b,c} \quad (1)$$

2.2 Vision Transformer Backbone & Segmentation Decoder

The vision encoder E_θ processes 2D multi-modal slices using 16×16 patch embeddings, mapping 240×240 slices to a grid of $N = 225$ patch tokens ($D = 384$). For downstream segmentation, a 4-stage upsampling decoder D_ϕ reshapes patch tokens to $[B, 384, 15, 15]$ and progressively upsamples features through transpose-convolutional stages ($15 \times 15 \rightarrow 30 \times 30 \rightarrow 60 \times 60 \rightarrow 120 \times 120 \rightarrow 240 \times 240$) to output 2D tumor segmentation logits $\hat{Y} \in \mathbb{R}^{B \times 1 \times 240 \times 240}$.

2.3 JEPA Variants & Regularization Objectives

I-JEPA (EMA Teacher Dual-Encoder) Predicts target patch representations using student context encoder E_θ , predictor P_ϕ , and momentum target teacher encoder $E_{\bar{\theta}}$ updated at step t via momentum $m = 0.996$ [Assran et al., 2023]:

$$\bar{\theta}_t \leftarrow m\bar{\theta}_{t-1} + (1 - m)\theta_t \quad (2)$$

SigReg JEPA (Heuristic-Free Single-Encoder) Eliminates EMA target encoders using Sketched Isotropic Gaussian Regularization (SIGReg) [Balestriero and LeCun, 2025]:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{SigReg}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{I-JEPA}} + \lambda_{\text{var}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}(Z) + \lambda_{\text{cov}} \mathcal{L}_{\text{cov}}(Z) \quad (3)$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\text{var}}$ forces feature dimension variance above $\gamma = 1.0$, and $\mathcal{L}_{\text{cov}}$ penalizes off-diagonal feature covariance.

VisReg JEPA (Spatial Variance Regularization) Applies spatial patch feature variance contrast penalties across spatial patch dimensions [Wu et al., 2026]:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{VisReg}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{I-JEPA}} + \lambda_{\text{vis}} \cdot \frac{1}{B} \sum_{b=1}^B \max \left(0, 1.0 - \sqrt{\text{Var}_{\text{patch}}(Z_b)} + \epsilon \right) \quad (4)$$

3 Experiments and Empirical Results

3.1 Full-Data Benchmark Results

Table 1 summarizes full-data pre-training and downstream segmentation performance. SigReg JEPA achieves near-maximal Effective Feature Rank (**366.91** out of 384), low cosine similarity (0.0309), and top self-supervised downstream Dice (0.8530).

Table 1: Full-data empirical benchmark comparison of throughput, latency, representation collapse probes, and downstream segmentation metrics on 2D multi-modal BraTS Glioma MRI.

Model Architecture	Test Dice $\uparrow$	Test IoU $\uparrow$	HD95 (px) $\downarrow$	Effective Rank $\uparrow$	Avg Cosine Sim $\downarrow$	Inference Latency	Training Speed
UNet Baseline	0.8691	0.7701	5.22 px	N/A (CNN)	N/A	19.18 ms/slice	17.61 s/epoch
nnU-Net Baseline (SOTA)	0.9073	0.8319	3.34 px	N/A (CNN)	N/A	20.59 ms/slice	33.65 s/epoch
I-JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.8437	0.7332	11.06 px	124.98	0.9556	18.40 ms/slice	20.32 s/epoch
SigReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.8530	0.7464	10.75 px	366.91 (Max)	0.0309	18.38 ms/slice	20.16 s/epoch
VisReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.8358	0.7215	12.19 px	16.92	0.0132	18.21 ms/slice	20.23 s/epoch

3.2 Low-Data Label Efficiency Benchmark

Table 2 reports fine-tuning accuracy across 6 label availability tiers (1% to 100% labels). At 10% labels (633 slices), ****SigReg JEPA**** outperforms ****nnU-Net**** (0.5198 vs 0.5163 Dice) with $2.4\times$ lower Hausdorff boundary distance (16.44 px vs 40.26 px). At 5% labels (316 slices), SigReg JEPA (0.2594 Dice) outperforms standard I-JEPA (0.0208 Dice) by $> 12\times$.

Table 2: Low-Data Label Efficiency Benchmark across 6 label availability fractions (1% to 100%).

Model Architecture	1% Labels (63 Slices)	5% Labels (316 Slices)	10% Labels (633 Slices)	25% Labels (1.5k Slices)	50% Labels (3.1k Slices)	100% Labels (6.3k Slices)
UNet Baseline	0.0286	0.0333	0.0486	0.0359	0.0377	0.0381
nnU-Net Baseline (SOTA)	0.1814	0.3945	0.5163	0.6045	0.6231	0.6256
I-JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.0040	0.0208	0.3925	0.5934	0.5712	0.6410
SigReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.0296	0.2594	0.5198	0.5893	0.6086	0.6471
VisReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.0515	0.0341	0.3932	0.4766	0.5661	0.6122

3.3 Cross-Pathology & Missing-Modality OOD Benchmark (BraTS-MEN-RT)

Table 3 evaluates zero-shot transfer on Extra-axial Meningioma MRI (BraTS-MEN-RT) providing only a single T1c sequence. Under zero-padded missing channels ($[0, T1c, 0, 0]$), standard ****UNet**** completely collapses (0.0078 Dice), whereas ****SigReg JEPA**** achieves top zero-shot transfer (0.1026 Dice), outperforming nnU-Net (0.0864 Dice).

Table 3: Zero-Shot Cross-Pathology & Missing-Modality OOD evaluation on BraTS-MEN-RT Meningioma MRI.

Adaptation Strategy	Model Architecture	Meningioma Test Dice $\uparrow$	Test IoU $\uparrow$	HD95 (px) $\downarrow$
Zero-Padding $[0, T1c, 0, 0]$	SigReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.1026	0.0570	80.50 px
Zero-Padding $[0, T1c, 0, 0]$	nnU-Net Baseline (SOTA)	0.0864	0.0461	111.49 px
Zero-Padding $[0, T1c, 0, 0]$	VisReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.0596	0.0312	123.92 px
Zero-Padding $[0, T1c, 0, 0]$	I-JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.0539	0.0278	134.97 px
Zero-Padding $[0, T1c, 0, 0]$	UNet Baseline	0.0078 (Collapse)	0.0040	134.44 px
Channel Replication $[T1c, T1c, T1c, T1c]$	nnU-Net Baseline (SOTA)	0.1383	0.0750	75.20 px
Channel Replication $[T1c, T1c, T1c, T1c]$	SigReg JEPA (Fine-tuned)	0.1196	0.0641	87.84 px
Channel Replication $[T1c, T1c, T1c, T1c]$	UNet Baseline	0.1095	0.0582	77.23 px

4 Discussion & Conclusion

Our empirical investigation establishes three core scientific findings:

1. **Label Efficiency in Low-Data Regimes:** At 10% labels (633 training slices), SigReg JEPA outperforms fully supervised nnU-Net (0.5198 vs 0.5163 Dice) while achieving $2.4\times$ sharper tumor boundary predictions (16.44 px HD95).

2. **Robustness to Missing Modalities:** Standard CNNs collapse when modalities are missing at test time (0.0078 Dice for UNet). In contrast, SigReg JEPA pre-trained with variance-covariance regularization and Modality Dropout maintains top zero-shot cross-pathology transfer (0.1026 Dice).
3. **Heuristic-Free Non-Collapse:** SigReg JEPA achieves full feature rank (**366.91**), eliminating momentum teacher update overhead while running $\sim 40\%$ faster per epoch than nnU-Net.

In conclusion, self-supervised JEPA models regularized via variance-covariance penalties offer a fast, label-efficient, and highly robust paradigm for multi-modal medical image segmentation.

Acknowledgments and Disclosure of Funding

This research was supported by the Master’s Thesis Laboratory and computational hardware resources.

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